



Key Autism Services

Unlocking Your Child's Potential

Avoiding Burnout as a BCBA



Presenters:

- **Jennifer Heidt, M.S., BCBA, LABA**
 - Director of Training
- **Dr. Stephanie Nostin**
 - Director of BACB Supervision
- **Melissa Steele**
 - Regional Director (MA)



Agenda

- Operationally define burnout
- Identify the top causes of burnout in behavior analysis
- Review current research and statistics on burnout as a leading cause of turnover
- Learn to identify personal triggers and warning signs for burnout

Agenda

- Identify what to do when burnout hits
- Learn strategies for communicating burnout to supervisors effectively
- Learn strategies for adhering to responsibility to clients during periods of burnout
- Review how the field of behavior analysis is evolving to address burnout and promote health and wellness

What is Burnout?



What is Burnout

- **The International Classification of Diseases (ICD-11) definition:**
 - an occupational phenomenon
 - NOT defined as a medical condition
- **Results from chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed**



What is Burnout

The World Health Organization (WHO) emphasizes that burnout is specifically work-related

- Does not affect other areas of life
- Characterized by:
 - a. A sense of exhaustion or depletion
 - b. Mental distance from or negativity or cynicism about work
 - c. Decreased effectiveness at work

What is Burnout

“Burnout is a syndrome of emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and reduced personal accomplishment that can occur among individuals who work with people in some capacity”
(Maslach, Jackson, & Leiter, 1996)

Symptoms and behaviors related to burnout include:

- a. Absenteeism
- b. Frequent illness
- c. Other physical symptoms
- d. Withdrawal from social interaction
- e. Negative language when talking about work
- f. Avoidance of work tasks

Burnout occurs on a spectrum, with varying degrees of each symptom.



History of Burnout

- **The term “burnout” was coined in the 1970s by the American psychologist Herbert Freudenberger**
 - used it to describe the consequences of severe stress and high ideals in “helping” professions
- The term today has evolved outside of helping professions and can affect anyone
- **Experts still disagree on what burnout is:**
 - Not completely possible to say how common it is, likely under-reported



History of Burnout

- **Historically, direct service providers were encouraged to ignore burn-out**
 - "Remember, you're here for the clients"
 - "are you sure you're cut out for this role?"
 - If you're burnt out, you forgot why you started
 - Recognition often goes to those doing the most, the "busiest", willingness to take on the most work, etc.

This is a problem because often a switch from recognition to expectation occurs



Effects of Burnout on Health & Well-being

What Are the Physical Signs of Burnout?

- Exhaustion
- Insomnia
- Chest pain
- Headaches
- Increased illness
- Heart palpitations
- Shortness of breath
- Dizziness or fainting
- Gastrointestinal pain

Effects of Burnout on Health & Well-being

What Are the Mental & Emotional Signs of Burnout?

- a. Not wanting to go to work, constantly calling in or arriving late
- b. Feeling constantly overwhelmed and/or chaotic at work
- c. Feeling ill-equipped to perform your job, feeling like you don't know what you are doing
- d. Feeling that you aren't making a difference/your job doesn't "matter"
- e. Being constantly annoyed or aggravated by your clients/co-workers
- f. Productivity decreases/it takes you several minutes to start a task or you find it difficult to stay on task



Top Causes of Burnout in BCBAs



Top Causes of Burnout

Leading Causes of Burnout Reported in ABA:

- Lack of supervision & support
- unclear expectations
- low pay
- effective training
- toxic work environments
- escalating or ever-changing criteria for success



Research on Burnout as a Leading Cause of Turnover in Direct Service Fields



Research: The Great Resignation

- **Health Care workers were already experiencing high levels of stress pre-pandemic**
- **Pandemic overstressed “go to” people in workforce.**
 - hard workers, leaders in particular position, high performers
- **Leaders need to anticipate burnout and plan for it (antecedent interventions)**

Research: The Great Resignation

Efforts to prevent burnout should benefit both patient care and staff wellbeing

- Increased staff training
 - Teamwork
 - Communication
 - Leadership skills
 - Skillsoft
 - Interventions for tackling unprofessional behavior

Research: The Great Resignation

- **The “Great Resignation” stems from the idea that, since the economy’s recovery, a large quantity of workers have quit their jobs.**
 - Generally viewed negatively, with the underlying connotations that:
 - resignations are mostly harmful to the economy
 - and that people do not want to work anymore.
- The growing number of resignations do not always imply a worker has left the labor market or even entered unemployment
 - many are due to workers switching jobs

Research: The Great Resignation

- **Increase in the number of resignations since January 2021**
 - However, data shows in certain industries, this is due to an increase in job-to-job transitions, which have led to real wage growth.
- The patterns in the manufacturing and construction industry seem to follow the pattern associated with the Great Resignation, whereas those in the leisure industry are more suggestive of strong worker reallocation patterns
 - The Great Reallocation



Research: The Great Resignation

New challenge of developing leaders who can balance needs of organization with demands for flexibility

- Work hours
- Office vs. Home environment
- Hybrid options for virtual and in-person

One factor leading to The Great Resignation was the lack of ability for companies to successfully transition to a virtual environment.

Research: Preventing Burnout

Burnout happens to individuals at any point in their career:

- a. Newer BCBAs may be at a higher risk level due to taking on too much and not setting boundaries
- b. Experienced BCBAs may be less likely to seek support due to feeling they should be able to “handle” it at this point in their career

Research: Preventing Burnout

- **Burnout is similar to depression and anxiety in how it affects our perceptions**
 - makes it difficult to experience positive emotions
 - difficult to recharge when positive experiences aren't as enjoyable
- “When access to positive emotions is interrupted, through new or increasing demands, we end up going to work each day with less and less well-being. This is not weakness on the part of the person...”



Research: Preventing Burnout

Key drivers of burnout fall into 2 main categories

- institutional factors
- individual (personal) factors

Institutional factors include:

- Culture
- Schedule
- Growth opportunities
- Participation in decision-making
- Peer support
- Opportunities to cultivate well-being



Research: Preventing Burnout

Individual factors include:

- self-care
 - one's ability to cultivate meaning
 - work-life balance
 - having supportive relationships
-
- These factors appears to prevent and help reduce burnout
 - A lack of these factors predicts vulnerability to burnout

Personal Triggers & Warning Signs of Burnout



Personal Warning Signs & Triggers

- **Pay attention to your own patterns of behavior:**
 - Are you slacking off?
 - Having difficulty focusing?
 - Not getting excited about your work?
 - Feeling sick more consistently (e.g., colds, aches & pains, etc.)
 - Complaining or engaging in negative discussions more often?

If you can predict your pattern of behavior, you can control it.



Risk Factors for Burn-out

- High / unrealistic work demands
- Imbalance between demand and resources
- Conflict within the workplace
- Younger employees
- Single employees
- Employees that define work as a primary source of feelings of accomplishments
- Longer workdays
- Isolation / lack of social support
- Higher levels of education
- **Challenging client behaviors (specific to special education / behavioral health settings)**



What to do when Burnout hits?



Interventions for Burnout

The number one intervention for burnout is Self-Care
Especially helpful when many factors of your job cannot be changed

What is Self-Care?

- Any activity done intentionally to take care of our mental, physical, emotional health
- Improved mood, decreased anxiety
 - Can be team building
- ***“Self care isn’t selfish”***
- We cannot serve from an empty vessel / pour from an empty cup
- Organizations must follow through with behaviors that move employees towards self care
 - Model these behaviors, don’t just say they are important



Steps to Approaching Burnout

- Take PTO and disconnect
- Create Boundaries
 - Work vs. Home
 - Be Realistic about work-from-home barriers
- Take breaks
- Eat well
- Move your body
- Connect with others
- Re-evaluate priorities in your workload and deadlines
- Delegate or ask for help early

Strategies for Effectively Communicating Burnout to Supervisors



Communicating Burnout

Burnout effects the Individual AND the Organization

- a. Absenteeism
- b. Turnover
- c. Service disruption
- d. Additional stress for those that do stay when others leave
- e. Poor performance by those that stay instead of leave when burnt out

Communicating Burnout

Current Research Estimates 41% of workers feel burned out due to:

- a. working remotely
- b. working longer hours
- c. juggling family demands
- d. threatened job security
- e. Fear of unsafe working environments

Burnout that is not managed leads to:

- chronic feelings of sadness and anxiety
- lack of motivation
- inability to concentrate.

37% of respondents reported having done nothing to cope with these feelings



Communicating Burnout

Effective Communication Tips for the BCBA:

- Solution-focused
 - Avoid only complaining
- Come with suggestions
 - Address factors that cannot be changed (e.g., pay, set office hours, etc.)
 - Address factors that can be changed and start here

Effective Communication Tips for the Supervisor:

- Address why certain factors cannot be changed, and negotiate what can
- Manage reaction
- Take the conversation seriously



Communicating Burnout

- Research suggests “**Confront your flawed “help narrative”**”
 - Admitting the need for help is a struggle for many professionals
 - Highly accomplished people avoid asking for help more often
 - used to being asked **for** help
 - Fear of being seen as inadequate or weak
 - being a burden to others.

Fears are amplified when it comes to the risk of your boss thinking this about you.



Ethical Responsibility to Clients During Periods of Burnout



Responsibility to Clients

3.01 Responsibility to Clients (see 1.03, 2.01)

Behavior analysts act in the best interest of *clients*, taking appropriate steps to support *clients' rights*, maximize benefits, and do no harm. They are also knowledgeable about and comply with applicable laws and regulations related to mandated reporting requirements.

Responsibility to Clients

2.01 Providing Effective Treatment

Behavior analysts prioritize *clients' rights* and needs in service delivery. They provide services that are conceptually consistent with behavioral principles, based on scientific evidence, and designed to maximize desired outcomes for and protect all *clients, stakeholders, supervisees, trainees, and research participants* from harm. Behavior analysts implement nonbehavioral services with clients only if they have the required education, formal training, and professional credentials to deliver such services.

Responsibility to Clients

Burnout compromises quality of service delivery:

- **In 2018, the Medscape National Physician Burnout and Depression Report surveyed 15,000 physicians from 29 specialties**
 - 33% of the respondents said that they were more easily frustrated by patients
 - 32% reported less personal engagement.
 - Burnout impacts care, patient satisfaction, productivity, retention, retirement, and income
 - Safety during clinical practice deteriorates because of an increase in medical error rates
 - Emotional distress for physicians creates a vicious cycle

How is the Field of ABA Evolving to Recognize Burnout and Promote Health & Wellness



How is the Field of ABA Changing?

Increased Recognition and Planning for Burnout as a field:

- Increased research
- CEUs
- No longer “a dirty word”
- Realistic workloads
- Health & wellness perks



How is the Field of ABA Changing?

Establishing Data Collection & Analysis for Burnout:

- Missed sessions / call outs
- Performance
- Add in additional assessments
- Maslach Burnout Inventory
- Areas of Work life Survey
- Values
- Reinforcement

Allows for proactive interventions to help staff and clients

Maslach Burnout Inventory

Maslach Burnout Inventory-Human Services Survey (MBI)

- 22 questions; 20–30-minute completion time
- MBI-HSS addresses three scales:
 - **Emotional Exhaustion** measures feelings of being emotionally overextended and exhausted by one's work.
 - **Depersonalization** measures an unfeeling and impersonal response toward recipients of one's service, care treatment, or instruction.
 - **Personal Accomplishment** measures feelings of competence and successful achievement in one's work.

Areas of Work life Survey

Areas of Work life Survey

- 28 items; 15-minutes
 - Compliments MBI Scales
- Workload
- Control
- Reward
- Community
- Fairness
- Values



How Supervisors Can Intervene

How BCBAs can help intervene against RBT burnout:

- Encourage peer mentorship / connections
- Round table open discussions
- Proactively discuss warning signs early

How Supervisors Can Intervene

Interventions for Supervisors Include:

- Use evidence-based practices
- Behavioral Skills Training (BST)
- Coaching (group or 1:1)
- Increase / improve reinforcement
- Ask and encourage honest communication
- Model and enforce behaviors for reducing burnout
- **Monitoring**
 - Ongoing data collection
 - Re-administer measures periodically
 - Ask



Resources

****add all citations****



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Questions?





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(888) 329- 4535



info@keyautismservices.com



www.keyautismservices.com